CHAPTER 6

DISPLACING INDIGENOUS PEOPLES

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master European settler colonialism in North America and Australia: displacement of Native Americans, the Gold Rush, Reservation policies, Trail of Tears, and the Australian 'Terra Nullius' myth.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Native American Worldview and Ecology:** Indigenous peoples lived in subsistence balance with nature; land was held in collective stewardship without private property deeds, practicing hunting, fishing, and communal farming.

• **European Settler Colonialism Mechanisms:** White settlers viewed land through capitalist ownership and commercial exploitation; acquired native lands through deceitful treaties, military coercion, and ecological destruction (slaughter of bison).

• **The Gold Rush and Expansion:** The 1840s California Gold Rush triggered rapid westward expansion, railway construction across tribal territories, and forced confinement of Native Americans into barren reservations ('Trail of Tears').

• **Australia and Terra Nullius:** British declared Australia 'Terra Nullius' (land belonging to no one), dispossessing Aboriginal peoples, suppressing indigenous languages, and creating the 'Stolen Generations' of forcibly removed children.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

Clash of Land Philosophies $\Longleftrightarrow$ Indigenous: Sacred Collective Stewardship $\longleftrightarrow$ Settler: Capitalist Private Ownership

Fundamental Ideological Rupture in Settler Colonialism

Displacement Vector $\rightarrow$ Deceitful Treaties $\rightarrow$ Bison Slaughter $\rightarrow$ Trail of Tears $\rightarrow$ Reservations

Systematic Dispossession Workflow of Native Americans

Terra Nullius Legal Fiction $\Longleftrightarrow$ Land Belonging to No One $\rightarrow$ Denial of Aboriginal Rights

British Imperial Justification for Australian Annexation

1849 Gold Rush $\rightarrow$ Trans-Continental Railroad $\longrightarrow$ Destruction of Frontier Ecology

Industrial Infrastructure Encroachment on Indigenous Lands

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** The term 'Terra Nullius' was a legal fiction used by British colonizers to justify seizing Australian land without signing any treaty or compensating Aboriginal owners.

• **Alert:** The 'Trail of Tears' refers specifically to the forced eviction of the Cherokee nation in 1838, where over 4,000 natives died of hunger and disease during a brutal forced march.

• **Alert:** Indigenous peoples were not nomadic wanderers without culture; they maintained complex oral histories, governance assemblies, artistic traditions, and linguistic diversity.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Contrast the Native American concept of land with that of European settlers. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Native American View:** Land was sacred and held collectively by the tribe as a communal gift of nature; they believed land could not be bought, sold, or partitioned into private fences. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **European Settler View:** Viewed land as private commodity to be cleared, fenced, purchased, and commercially exploited for cash crop agriculture, timber, and mining profits. **[1.5 Marks]**

2. Explain the methods used by European settlers to displace indigenous peoples in North America. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Deceitful Treaties:** Forced tribal leaders to sign treaties relinquishing ancestral lands for negligible compensations that were often never paid. **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Ecological Destruction:** Mass slaughtered millions of American bison (buffalo), depriving plains natives of their primary source of food, clothing, and shelter. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Military Expulsion (Trail of Tears):** Used the US Army to forcibly march entire tribes westward into barren reservations; thousands perished from exposure and exhaustion. **[1 Mark]**

• **4. Cultural Assimilation:** Established boarding schools where native children were forbidden from speaking their languages or practicing ancestral customs. **[1 Mark]**

3. What was the California Gold Rush? How did it impact the development of the United States? [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Meaning:** The sudden mass migration of thousands of fortune seekers (the 'Forty-Niners') to California following the discovery of gold traces at Sutter's Mill in 1848. **[1 Mark]**

• **Impact on Development:** Accelerated the building of transcontinental railways, expanded industrial manufacturing, and led to rapid settlement of the Pacific coast at catastrophic cost to indigenous inhabitants. **[2 Marks]**

4. Explain the concept of 'Terra Nullius' in Australia and discuss how it affected Aboriginal peoples. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Concept:** A British legal doctrine meaning 'land belonging to nobody'; applied to Australia on the false claim that Aboriginal inhabitants did not practice agriculture or recognize land ownership. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Dispossession Impact:** Allowed British authorities to seize millions of acres without signing treaties or paying compensations, driving Aboriginals into harsh desert interiors. **[1 Mark]**

• **Stolen Generations:** Government policies forcibly removed thousands of mixed-descent Aboriginal children from their mothers to assimilate them into white foster homes and institutions. **[1.5 Marks]**

5. What was the significance of the Indian Reorganisation Act of 1934 in the United States? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Significance:** Reversed previous aggressive assimilation policies, recognized native tribes as distinct legal entities, and granted reservation communities the right to establish local tribal self-government. **[2 Marks]**

6. What was the historic Mabo decision of 1992 in Australia? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **The Mabo Ruling:** The High Court of Australia overturned the doctrine of 'Terra Nullius', legally ruling that indigenous Aboriginal people held prior native title rights to their ancestral lands before British arrival. **[2 Marks]**